

No love, however brief, is wasted

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by [Iriascend](#)

Summary

Jason isn't exactly sure how it happened.

One moment he's planning on how to off Joker and take over Gotham from Batman, the next he's being scented by a very loudly purring Nightwing.

Then the night just gets weirder.

Notes

The title comes from a thread from Louise Miller on Twitter, about how even experiences that don't result in a "useful" skill, still have merit: [link](#).

Does this have a plot? A point? No. It's just cute and Jason deserves good things. Fight me.

The plot bunny this came out of was "what if everyone was head-over-heels for Jason instead of angry/fearful when he got back, and he sort of short-circuits?" but it went off the rails pretty fast.

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

At first, it's a normal evening. He's loitering on a fire escape, enjoying some downtime while keeping an eye on the mob lieutenant living across the street. He absolutely does not expect anything to interrupt him — he barely arrived in Gotham and nobody should have any reason to take interest in him. He's confident he's low profile enough in his civvies not to garner attention from anyone, including the Bats.

That is his mistake.

Jason only notices he has company by the tell-tale *thump* of a vigilante landing nearby. He tries to turn around and brace himself, but Nightwing corners him with the swiftness of a predator before he manages to do anything meaningful.

Fuck alphas and their reflexes.

He never expected to be this close to Dick anytime soon, so his mind begins to race. What does the man want with him? Did Batman send him? Are they going to have to fight? Does he even recognize him?

He's been already carrying out minor capers to set himself up on the Gotham crime scene, but nothing that would set the Bats off just yet. He's taken care to always be anonymous, too, face hidden under his helmet, so they shouldn't be able to recognize him out of costume anyway. Not after all the years and all the changes; he's nothing like that gangly, freshly-presented baby omega he was back then.

By all means, they shouldn't be able to tell it's him. So what business does Nightwing have with who should be a random Gothamite to him? Jason has to talk his way out of this before-

He doesn't get to formulate an exit strategy though because Nightwing unceremoniously grabs him by the wrist and peels off his scent blocker patch without much issue. He takes a tentative sniff, then gasps.

"Little wing...?" Dick whispers, voice weirdly solemn.

Ah, fuck. He recognizes the smell, even despite it changing with all the shit Jason's been through.

Fighting it is, then.

To Jason's surprise, the vigilante doesn't stiffen in confusion or scowl in anger at the realisation that he's holding his long-dead packmate. No, Nightwing starts *purring*.

Jason immediately forces the omegan instinct to respond in a similar fashion into the back of his brain where it belongs.

"The hell?" he chokes out instead, not managing anything more eloquent when he's caught so off-guard.

Nightwing's expression softens when he hears his voice. "It's you. It's really you." He starts rubbing his cheek over the now-exposed wrist gland. It only makes Jason spiral further into shock.

For a few moments, they remain like that. Then Jason yanks his arm away and growls in a warning.

"What the fuck are you doing?" he snaps, trying to pat the adhesive patch back onto his skin.

"Scenting you? You don't smell like pack at all anymore." Nightwing seems genuinely confused by his question. Then he scrambles to peel off a scent blocker of his own, offering his hand to Jason as if thinking that's what upset him.

"*My scent* is what you're worried about? Really?"

"Yeah? Nothing else--"

"Not even how I'm supposed to be *dead*?"

"I've seen weirder things as a hero, honestly. Besides, I'm not going to complain about a miracle, especially not one most of us had been praying for so often."

"Thoughts and prayers, huh? I should've known that's all you can do. If you care so much, why is Joker still alive?!"

"He's... not?" Dick says hesitantly, but plainly, as if that doesn't shatter Jason's entire worldview.

"*What?*" Jason can't decide whenever he's not sure if he heard right, or he just doesn't believe what he heard.

"I personally made sure."

"What?!" Talia had told him Batman hadn't killed the Joker. He never thought to check if *anyone else* did, assuming Bruce would *stop* them.

"Even got a memento. See?" Dick pulls his upper lip away with a finger, exposing his teeth. One of his canines is missing a good chunk and once Jason takes a look, Dick grins as if he was showing off *a trophy*. "Bit down too hard and chipped it against Joker's spine when I was tearing his throat out."

"WHAT?!" Jason yells, entirely too loud, trying to make sense of the world that's rapidly losing it. Dick must misinterpret his confusion as distress because he starts explaining himself, sounding rather... insecure.

"After... After your- funeral I... went feral," Dick says, avoiding eye contact. Then he suddenly looks up, alarmed. "I'm safe now, I swear! I went to therapy and I'm all good. Hadn't lost control in years." Nightwing raises his hands to show how non-threatening he is. Jason feels like he's going to faint. "B and I are still on thin ice, though, since I did go off the

rails pretty badly. But just between you and me? I don't regret a thing. He *took you from us*. What kind of alpha would I be if I hadn't avenged you?"

"I don't know, *one just like B?*" he snarls, kind of performatively because he can't really make himself angry at the moment. Dick... killed? For him? They've been praying for him, kept his memory alive? His head is swimming, dizzy with the implications of this new, confusing information. The comforting, familiar alpha smell right under his nose and the constant purring isn't helping, either.

"... you think he hadn't..." Dick seems genuinely bewildered. It throws Jason off. Isn't it obvious?

"I thought he just moved on," he says with a fake shrug.

"He didn't go on a grand hunt, fair. His anger was less... *focused* than mine. But he was just as devastated, maybe even more. And it wasn't pretty. He took it out on everything and everyone, including himself. I'd even go as far as to say he... went his own kind of feral for a while." Dick sighs sadly and shakes his head. "We alphas might seem like we can take anything, but those kinds of wounds... we just don't know what to do with them."

"You two could barely stand me back then. Why would you even care? I thought you'd be... glad I was gone."

"What? No!" Nightwing grabs Jason's hands and brings them up to his face, nuzzling into his fingers gently in a gesture of reassurance. Then his expression hardens and he looks back up, frowning. "*Who told you that?*"

"...Talial Al Ghul," Jason admits, feeling a slight blush creeping up on his cheeks without his consent. Al Ghuls aren't the most... trustworthy bunch, after all, but it all seemed to check out...

Now he's not sure what to believe.

Dick raises a single eyebrow at him, then smiles, offering his hand again in a clear invitation to follow him. "Let me set the record straight then, Little wing. Back home you'll see with your own eyes just how much you mean to us, how much we miss you every day."

For just a moment, Jason allows himself to wonder, *what if Talial lied?* And it's easy from there.

They come down from the fire escape holding hands as if Dick is afraid Jason would run if he lets go of him (and in any other situation, that would be a correct assumption). But now, Jason hops onto Nightwing's bike without much thought, letting him take him to the BatCave like he wasn't dreading even seeing the place just yesterday. He suspects it's half curiosity, half his hindbrain getting way over-excited about the prospect of having a pack again. Perhaps he still is that hopeful kid he used to be back then, after all.

He expected to freak out about it way more, honestly. But he's... weirdly relaxed. Maybe having your face firmly pressed against the back of Dick's head, inhaling the soft, truly

thrilled alpha smell straight off his hair, he thinks, is comforting enough to quell nearly all anxiety.

Thirty minutes later he realises that it's not. His insecurities and anger rear their ugly heads right back up again in full glory when they arrive at their destination.

The Cave is as dramatically goth and drab as he remembers it, with just one jarring exception: the scrawny kid that peeks into the garage the moment they get off the bike.

"Dick? I didn't expect you tonight. Is everything al- ..."

Tim Drake.

Pretender Robin.

"...*you replaced me*," Jason whispers to nobody in particular, hurt shining in his voice. He almost forgot about it, caught up in Dick's smooth words and comfy promises. But it's here, clear as day: they have a new fool to take his place in the pack.

It's even worse than he thought. Drake's not just a proper, posh upper-class kid, clever and smart and obedient in all the right ways. Not just a better Robin and a better packmate. He's also all Jason was supposed to be, all an omega should be — attentive, graceful and unbelievably pretty.

A low, threatening growl escapes out of Jason's throat, echoing in the vast, empty room.

"...Jason?" Drake's mouth drops open in shock, then he winces as if something hurt him. "Jason Todd?"

Just as Dick, he apparently somehow recognizes Jason instantly, but his reaction is different. He takes off, haphazardly, runs towards them nearly tripping over his own feet. His pupils are blown in a mix of confusion and something twisted — pain? maybe terror? Jason can't tell, the kid smells like *nothing*, clearly fresh out of the shower with his hair still damp.

Drake is either incredibly stupid or incredibly self-confident because he skids to a stop only mere feet away from Jason — well within melee distance of the guy twice his size that's clearly upset and possibly wants to bash his head in.

Dick must sense the tension despite Jason's scent blockers dampening the most obvious sign; he's close enough to see how Jason's shoulders stiffen up and his breathing becomes slow, heavy with rage. So, he gently grabs onto Jason's arm, probably trying to calm him down, trying to stop the inevitable bloodbath that's about to follow. Drake, though, instead of bracing for a fight, does something... unforeseen.

He drops to his knees, his legs hitting the ground with a painful-sounding *thud*, and bares his throat. Even goes as far as to pull the collar of his t-shirt down to expose more vulnerable flesh. There are tears rolling down his cheeks and his breathing is laboured.

Jason freezes. Squints. Thinks. If the kid expects him to go easy on him just because-

Then it hits him.

It's faint, the kid must've doused himself in soap and scrubbed himself raw in the post-patrol shower, but it's there.

The faint smell of a scared, pleading, *reverent*... alpha.

Jason had assumed that Drake's an omega; an omega that they replaced him with, an omega that usurped his place in the pack and now, presented with an obviously stronger contender, tries to act like he didn't.

But it turns out that despite how much he looks like one, Drake's *not* an omega.

No. He's an alpha, young and healthy and with all the reasons to consider himself higher in the hierarchy than a vagabond, strange omega he's just met. And still, he recognised Jason and submitted to him in a heartbeat, without any hesitation.

Why? Why would he ever do that? Because of the eulogies he's heard about Jason? Because of some misguided respect for the previous Robin? Because of the way Dick treated Jay in the few seconds he saw?

Drake's quiet whine snaps Jason out of his thoughts. The kid scans him for a moment, then closes his eyes shut, trembling, fear seeping into his smell. He's still dutifully waiting for Jason to revoke his initial hostility and rejection, asking — in a very traditional, outdated way — to be acknowledged, to be approved of, to be accepted.

To be allowed into the pack as if he wasn't the one currently living in the Manor, as if a single word from Jason could sever his ties with the Waynes in an instant.

And somehow, seeing Dick's trepidation, smelling the fluctuating apprehension in the alphas' smells, Jason believes that would be the case. It's his decision. If he just so desires, he can reject the kid and throw him out. And sure, people would probably try to convince him to change his mind, but it feels like they wouldn't... question him if he stood his ground. Not even Drake himself.

And that... that isn't something he ever expected.

He swallows, trying to ground himself, and looks at Dick, seeking reassurance because he once again today feels a little dizzy. Dick smiles encouragingly, so Jay slowly reaches out towards the alpha at his feet. Puts his hand on Tim's head and shyly... pets his hair. What else could he possibly do, what argument does he have against them? None. None at all.

He's instantly rewarded with Tim's relieved sigh and then quiet purring, which Dick quickly picks up, too.

Apparently, they indeed care about Jason very much.

Who would've thought.

Dick takes a detour towards the showers, promising he'll catch up with them in just a moment, while Tim sheepishly accompanies Jason upstairs to meet Alfred. Jay insisted on talking to the elder; he's here already, and the butler is by far his favourite person. Even if everything goes to shit later, he wants to at the very least say "hi" to his adoptive grandfather.

They run into the man just past the threshold of the study; he must've been on his way to usher Tim to sleep.

Alfred immediately drops the mug of — judging by the scent — chamomile tea and it shatters, splashing his perfectly polished shoes with warm liquid. He doesn't seem to mind, though. He gasps, eyes filling with tears uncontrollably, then rushes towards Jason. He opens his arms and sweeps Jay into a hug.

"My dear boy," Alfred whispers, inhaling the tiny bits of Jason's scent from his hair that he can get.

Jason chuckles awkwardly, peeling the neck blocker patch off to let the elder scent him properly. Alfred doesn't hesitate to indulge, rubbing his wrists all over the skin until Jason smells like home again.

Jay feels like he's treated like a pup, but it's not a bad feeling. He hasn't realised how much he wished, though never consciously, that this would happen. He thinks that maybe... maybe even facing Bruce won't be that hard.

"I'm back, Alfie. I'm back."

He hides his face in the elder's shoulder. Tim stands to the side, uncomfortably wringing his hands for a second, then wanders off only to return with a broom and a rag a moment later; he cleans up the spilled tea while Alfred and Jason are having a moment.

"How do y'all keep recognisin' me right away, tho?" Jason asks once he feels hugged enough for the night. "I'm nothing like I used to be."

"You've grown a lot and your scent has indeed changed, but the pack bonds are unmistakable."

Jason frowns in confusion. Tim and Alfred frown in reaction to his confusion. Dick bursts into the room, hair still soaking wet and domino barely off his face, then stops abruptly to stare at them.

"What happened?" he asks, scrunching his nose at the obvious stress in Alfred's scent. "Is everything okay?"

"That can't be it," Jay snaps, ignoring Dick, annoyed at the fact that out of all people, Alfred insists on lying. "I'm not bonded with y'all anymore."

Dick tilts his head, then pats his chest over where his heart is. "You very much are," he says. "That's how I found you. The bond's been cold for years, but it warmed up when I got close

to you. Almost fell off a roof when I felt it.”

“*Stop bullshitting me,*” Jason growls in response, causing Tim to hide behind Dick on instinct. “It’s not pack bonds. I’d feel it. *How did you clock me?*”

Dick’s smell sours instantly, but with sadness instead of fear or upset as Jason would’ve expected. “...you don’t feel it?”

The honesty in his voice and how truly genuine that question sounds makes Jason put a full stop to his rising anger. He looks at him for a moment, silent, still frowning, then drops his gaze down to the floor.

“Why would I?” Jason mumbles. “I’m not in the pack anymore.”

“But you *are!*” Dick insists.

“I’m not! You forgot about me! Threw me out!”

“We didn’t!”

“Then why can’t I feel you?!” Jason snaps, baring his teeth, and for a moment it looks like they’re going to fight. Then, to Jason’s surprise, Tim speaks up, peeking out from behind Dick’s back.

“Unrequited bonding,” the teen says, quietly, in a very sad tone.

Dick whips around to look at him, confused. “What?”

“Much like relationships and emotions, pack bonds can sometimes be one-sided,” he explains to him and Dick pales. “*You* didn’t sever the bonds. But—”

“*But he did*” doesn’t quite make it past his lips, though everyone present knows that’s what would follow if Tim had the guts to continue.

“I didn’t either,” Jason growls threateningly. How dare the kid suggest that he’d- He points to Dick. “B and me didn’t always see eye-to-eye, but- I didn’t- I died trying to reach out to him!”

Tim gasps and starts talking before Dick can react at all. “*That’s it.* You died, and your bonds with you. Whatever brought you back-” he looks up at Jason, and for a second he’s not reserved anymore; there’s no trepidation in his eyes, only cunning and curiosity and clever wit. Like that, his designation finally makes sense, Jay thinks. “What brought you back?”

Jason squints, then crosses his arms over his chest defiantly, trying to avoid elaborating on that unsavoury detail. “Even if that’s the case, still doesn’t explain how *you* recognized me,” he says, scowling. “We’ve never been pack.”

Tim’s eyes blow wide and he takes a step back, reverting to his previous, shy demeanour.

“That- I- uh-” he stammers as his cheeks turn red. “I... I actually-... it’s-... a parasocial thing, nothing important, but I’ve... I’ve sorta-kinda bonded with you? With Robin? Back in the day? It was more like imprinting than-”

“You can’t pack-bond with someone you don’t know.”

“Um. I. I actually knew you. At least enough to, you know— ”

“Yeah, Tim’s had us figured out and had been stalking both Batman and Robin, without us even noticing,” Dick throws in with fake perkiness, putting his arm protectively over the teen’s shoulders, probably sensing how agitated Jason is again, and how much it affects Tim. “He’s a smart little cookie like that.”

Jason shelves the thought of a kid figuring out Batman’s identity for later.

“Even if, why would a spoiled kid bond with a random vigilante?!”

Somehow, Tim turns an even darker shade of red and he wrings his fingers again. When he responds, his voice is such a tiny whisper that Jason almost has to ask him to repeat.

“Because I didn’t have anyone else.”

As the words and their implications actually register with Jason, all his rage dissipates and he can’t help but hug the kid just like Dick does.

"Master Bruce had made a hobby out of caring for pups in need, master Jason. How could we refuse young master Timothy? But just as you hadn’t taken master Dick’s place, neither had master Timothy taken yours." Alfred finally speaks up, as if not to let the ugly emotions rise any further. His tone is level and soothing. “We’ve never forgotten you, master Jason. The bonds may have frayed on your end, but... if you’d like to, your spot in the Wayne pack is waiting for you, as it always had.”

Jason lets Tim go and looks away. It’s not-... it’s nothing like he expected and he doesn’t know what to do with himself anymore. So, he just asks:

“... after all this time?”

The reply comes from all of the Waynes in front of him, like it echoes through the bonds they share.

“Always.”

They don’t quite manage to apologise for all the shouting and accusations, but it’s nothing new between him and Dick; nothing time and a little purring can’t fix. So when Dick invites him into his den for overnight scenting, Jason agrees. And if Tim is dragged along, well, that’s just between the three of them. Jason’s now the pack omega of the Waynes, apparently, and the bonds have to start again with *something*, after all.

It feels like rebuilding the bonds should be hard — it took so long the first time around for Jason to open up — like it should take weeks, if not months, and require lots of talking and carefully adjusting one to another. And yes, truly close relationships and full trust is still a song of the future. But Jason feels a wave of warmth washing over him when he finally crawls out of bed the next day, and he knows that kind of cosy comfort, even if it's been a long time since the last time he experienced it.

Dick smiles at him, no doubt feeling and thinking the same thing. Tim just grumbles something about coffee, trying to make his way towards the door, and Jason can't help but sweep him off his feet and carry him to the kitchen, despite his loud shriek of disapproval and Dick's rumbling laughter.

Bruce finds them there, chatting with Alfred over the kitchen island, when he returns from a party he had to attend to keep the appearances up as Brucie. He opens the door forcefully but slowly and with care, a clear sign that he's both excited and scared. He must've felt the rollercoaster shifts in the pack bonds overnight, and Jason can't quite imagine how hard it must've been to try to look nonchalant when so much turmoil was happening inside him.

The man doesn't dare make a single step inside the room when he sees them, when his eyes confirm what his bonds are saying.

"... Jaylad?" B whispers softly.

Jason looks him up and down and briefly considers pretending he's someone else, just to fuck with him. His plan is foiled when Dick starts enthusiastically nodding from across the counter, so Jay waves at B. It's sloppy, and stunted, because he kind of expects something to blow up in his face; everything is going way too good, and Bruce — while great, mostly — is not known to handle emotions very well.

"It's me, old man," he confirms, not daring to say anything more.

Bruce doesn't seem the least agitated. Quite the contrary, he looks like he's on the verge of crying of joy, dancing and thanking whatever gods there are, and it kind of makes it even more awkward for Jason.

"How...?"

He shrugs. "It's a long story," he dodges, trying to change the topic, "and I ain't talkin' before I finish breakfast, so shut up and get your fat ass over here if you want to get started on the frantic scenting that I know you're *dying* to do."

Bruce doesn't waste a second. It seems like he can't decide where to put his hands first, on Jason's neck or wrists or hair or cheek or— eventually, he settles for a bear hug and shoves his face into Jason's shoulder.

"My boy. I missed you so much."

And it takes all of Jason's willpower not to tear up when he hears that. He hadn't even realised how much he wanted to hear it. He reciprocates the hug and lets Bruce scent him.

“You’ve grown so much,” Bruce says when he finally pulls away, though he still is cupping his face and looking at him with glazed eyes like he thinks Jason’s going to disappear if he lets go of him. “I failed you, I’m so sorry. For everything. For-”

“It’s fine,” Jason interrupts him, not wanting to discuss the past just yet. “I’m home now, dad. I’m home.”

“You are, son. You are,” B says with a sigh, and Jason lets the old man savour the hug for a moment.

After well over two minutes though, Bruce is still not letting go and it starts to feel a little weird, so Jason pushes up from the chair he’s sitting on. In doing so, he throws Bruce slightly off-balance; he bumps one of the mugs off the counter with his elbow. Its warm contents spill all over Jason’s lap, making him curse under his breath.

That causes something Jason hadn’t expected to happen: all three alphas jump to alert in a heartbeat.

“Are you okay?” Dick asks, immediately closing the distance between them.

Bruce is already looking over his legs. “Did you get burned?”

Tim is next to him before he can even blink, with a kitchen towel in his hands. For a moment he seems to want to pat Jason dry himself, but eventually opts for just handing him the towel.

“Oh dear,” Alfred, weirdly enough, seems to be the one least frazzled by the incident. “Master Timothy, be so kind and grab me a broom.”

The kid nods, but doesn’t move. He, Dick and Bruce have their eyes glued to Jason.

“What?” Jay asks. “I’m fine, I ain’t made of glass. It wasn’t even hot.”

That seems to do it, because Tim takes off, and Bruce and Dick smile in relief.

“You should get changed,” Dick suggests.

“Don’t have any other clothes with me, though.”

“We... still have your old things,” Dick mentions, slightly unsure. Tim throws him a crooked glance as he hands Alfred the broom, then pointedly looks Jason up and down.

“Don’t think he’ll fit in them anymore.” The older alpha takes a breath in, but Tim cuts him off before he can speak. “Yours would also be too small, Dick.”

Jason snorts. He and Tim will be good friends if he can talk Dick shut like that.

“Master Bruce seems to be of similar build to master Jason,” Alfred says off-handedly, not even looking up. Bruce murmurs a noise of thought.

“If you’re alright with wearing them...?” he asks sheepishly, glancing at Jason.

The thought of being enveloped in Bruce's smell makes him happier than he ever expected.

Bruce finds him in the library, later in the day.

"Shouldn't you be at work o' somethin'?" Jason asks from above his steaming teacup.

"I took the day off," Bruce replies, "Couldn't quite focus. We have so much to catch up on."

Jason gives him a lopsided smile and lets him continue.

"I thought we could start by refreshing your room? Alfred kept it clean but I doubt you'll fit in your old bed."

"I'm pretty sure I will. Aren't all the beds here King-sized or something?"

"Not quite. They're all bigger than the usual kind, yes, but yours was, well, child-sized."

"You're just looking for an excuse, aren't you."

"Can you blame me?"

Jason laughs, then stands up from the armchair, putting his tea down. "No, I really can't."

"Good, because I already moved the old bed out and need help bringing a bigger one down from the attic."

Alfred interrupts them in the middle of the little renovation with an afternoon snack. He puts the tray down and looks around the newly rearranged room with a smile. The approval of their elder fills Jason and Bruce with joy.

"You know, this all feels... like a dream," Jason sighs, reaching for a cookie. "I never expected to come back to the Manor, let alone be welcomed like this."

Alfred nods in understanding. "I'm hoping you'll feel at home here soon, then."

"Speaking of that," Bruce interjects, "Where have you been staying before?"

"A little apartment in the Bowery. I should probably go back and clean the place up if I'm to move back in here."

"Is there anything in particular you want to grab?"

Jason shrugs. "No, not really. Just don't want to leave gear and intel lying around, you know?"

"I can drive you there, if you'd like."

Jason gives the offer some thought. “That’d be nice, actually.”

“You should visit the shopping district on your way back,” Alfred notes.

“Good thinking, Alfred. We should get Jay some clothes to wear before the ones I ordered arrive,” Bruce says, but Alfred isn’t quite satisfied with his thought process.

“I also meant that it’d been quite some time since the last time the Manor had housed a grown omega. We might be lacking on some essential supplies.”

“Oh, no, I don’t need anything special-”

“No, Alfred’s right, we have to stock up,” Bruce says, and his smile grows wider. “We’re getting you the fluffiest nesting materials in the world, chum.”

“What for? Just because I’m a ‘mega doesn’t mean-”

“But you’re my son and you deserve it.”

And how can Jason disagree with *that* reasoning?

Since Dick went back to his own apartment — though he loudly promised to visit very soon! — and duties finally caught back up to Bruce, Jason was expecting to have the evening to himself. Then Tim knocks on his door.

“Can I come in?” the teen asks with more reluctance than would seem normal. It strikes Jason as odd, then he realises that this is his nest, his territory, and he and Tim aren’t very close. It’s understandable the alpha is unsure how welcome he is in here.

“Yeah,” he answers, trying to sound friendly.

Tim pops his head into the room. “I brought you hot chocolate.”

It feels like a bribe or an offering to try to get into Jason’s good graces.

Jay points to his bedside table. Tim hesitates for a moment, then slides in and walks over to put the mug down. Then he starts nervously wringing his fingers again. If what Dick said is true, the kid considered Jason a packmate for a long time before they even met, and must’ve idolized Robin a lot. It’s no wonder he’s a bit... unsure how to act now.

Jason gives him time.

“I was wondering...” Tim starts when it’s obvious that Jason won’t tell him to leave. “If you’d like to hang out sometime? I’m-”

“Sure.”

The kid’s eyes go big as if he’d just heard he won the lottery. “Really?”

“I mean, we’re packmates now, aren’t we? Properly, I mean. Gotta get to know you.”

Jason pats the bed next to himself, inviting Tim to sit down, and Tim’s so excited he almost trips over his own feet on his way there.

“So, Dick said you figured B’s identity out on your own?”

“Well...”

Dick visits, as promised, the next day. They opt to talk while getting their daily workouts done in the gym down in the BatCave. Since Nightwing is by far less tactful than Alfred and beats around the bush less than Bruce, the topic quickly drifts towards what Jason was doing since he came back to life.

“The plan wasn’t fully formed yet, but I wanted to clean up the streets of Gotham in... a way B probably wouldn’t approve of. Crime Alley needs someone who *knows* how it works, you know?”

Dick makes a non-descript noise of acknowledgement but doesn’t answer, probably not wanting to get caught in the middle of any future moral debates between Jason and Bruce.

“I was planning to go by Red Hood, actually,” Jason admits. Dick looks at him, frowning, from his elevated position on the aerial gym.

“... isn’t that an old alias of-“

“Of Joker, yeah. I’m a dramatic bitch, okay?” Jason laughs and puts the weights down with a sigh. He cracks his neck and tries to work out a knack in his upper back that’s been bothering him, but the movement only makes it worse. He hisses in pain then sits down, only to suddenly end up face-to-face with a worried Dick.

“What’s wrong?”

“How the fuck did you get down here so fast?”

Dick ignores the question. “Did you hurt yourself?”

“I’m fine, it’s just a-” he starts to explain, and this time it’s Tim that interrupts him. He has a small, portable medkit in his hands and looks flushed, like he was sprinting a moment ago.

“What happened?”

Jason looks between the two alphas. It would be funny how badly their instincts got the better of them if he didn’t have a cramp between his shoulder blades.

“I’m fine, knotheds,” he groans. “My back’s just stiff.”

Tim tilts his head, scanning him for a brief moment. He pulls a muscle rub cream out of the medkit and hands it to Dick without a word, then goes back to finish his reports at the Batcomputer.

Dick raises his eyebrows expectantly at Jason. And Jason can't do anything else but sigh, turn around and lift the back of his shirt. It's not like he's going to complain about a free back massage.

Jason assumes that when the novelty of him coming back ends, the special, over-excited treatment will also disappear. His time in the pack before his death was short-lived, there's no chance they got attached to him this much. It's probably mostly their alpha instincts going haywire at finally having an omega around, and one that they consider having been hurt and lost before. He wholeheartedly believes things will level out soon. During the darker hours of the night, he thinks it's maybe even just because he's an omega, and despises it, despises how he probably doesn't even register as a *person* to them, just as his designation. His brain even goes as far as conjuring up scenarios where they throw him out when the initial infatuation fades, realising how broken he is, how much they used to not care about him before he presented.

None of that ever happens; quite to the contrary, the weird, protective behaviours pick up in intensity with time. Instead of hugs and scenting, he's getting the full service of a pack omega. Bruce almost breaks his public persona of a ditz and *growls* at a stranger who bumps into Jason on the street. Dick looks about ready to murder a man when Jason gets punched during patrol (because of course he joined them in the vigilante work; Bruce took one look at Jason and knew he can't keep him off the streets. They did have a heated debate about the guns, though.). Tim doesn't do anything possessive like they do, but when Jason makes an off-hand comment about him not taking proper care of himself, the next morning the kid has a green smoothie and a book on nutrition in his hands instead of a can of soda. When he stubs his toe against a piece of equipment in the Cave, Bruce appears at his side with a worried expression in an instant, and Alfred insists on having a look like he's concerned that Jason broke a bone or something.

It's... confusing, to say the least.

It all falls into place two weeks later, when he runs into Cassandra for the first time, in the living room. She isn't the least surprised to find a new person in the Manor, and seems to already know who he is, so someone must've told her about him. Or maybe she just picked up his presence through the pack bonds when she came home and decided to immediately meet her new packmate.

They've just came back from the patrol and Jason is the first to come up from the Cave, not having to wash all the excess sweat and alpha musk off himself.

"Little brother!" shouted excitedly in the shadows is his only warning before a small, Asian girl tackles his side. Luckily, he's already heard about her (and that she should be back from a

mission in Hong Kong soon) from Alfred, otherwise, he'd probably freak out and throw her across the room.

"I'm anything *but* little," he comments, trying to pull her away to at least take a look at her, but she's weirdly good at clinging to him despite his efforts.

"Younger. So little brother."

"Wait, I'm *younger* than you?"

She nods, then stands on her toes and noses at his neck. "Bad smell," she says, rubbing her cheek against his as if wanting to cover up his 'bad' scent.

"The fuck is that supposed to mean?"

"Tired. Worried. Sad."

Jason grunts. He can't disagree with that, but he's also surprised she is able to pick up those notes; they should be well-hidden and faint by now, too.

"I protect," she adds, finally making eye contact.

If she was an alpha, Jason would have a hard time not getting offended at that. Just because he's an omega doesn't mean he's weak and he's more than happy to prove it. But she smells mellow, with distant, flowery notes, which means she's a beta. It's unlikely she had any sexism in mind with her remark, so he gives her the benefit of doubt, since it's their first meeting.

"I can protect myself, Cass."

"I know."

"So I don't need your help."

"You do. No time to do all."

"And what else should I be doing, huh?"

"Happy."

"What?" Jason chokes out.

"Lost time. Need to catch up on fun. So I protect. Bruce did for me, I do for you."

The floor behind them creaks as someone walks into the room. "*We* do for you," Bruce corrects her, and a murmur of agreement from Tim and Dick, standing behind him, follows.

Jason smiles, trying to hide how his eyes tear up at the sudden realisation that hits him. True, he's lost time, and memories, and many other things. He's broken, harsh and difficult, and he expected to be thrown away when they realize how much he doesn't fit everyone else, now

more than ever. He expected that the brief period of happiness in the Manor he had, the hope for the future that Bruce once gave him and the love he had finally experienced were wasted.

But apparently no matter what the Al Ghuls wanted Jason to believe, no matter how difficult his origins or how turbulent his return... no matter how short his time with the pack was in the past, the Waynes loved him.

And it turns out, briefness doesn't mean insignificance.

End Notes

If you wanna say hi or talk with me, you can find me over on [Tumblr](#) :)

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